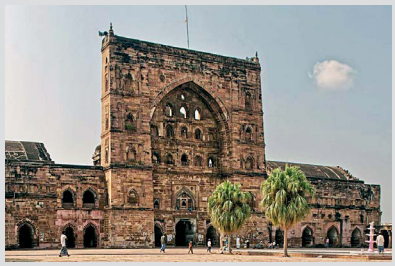
OTHER U.P. FLASHPOINTS

GYANVAPI MOSQUE
VARANASI
Claim: 'Shivling' found in ablution pond in a 2022 survey

SHAHI IDGAH MOSQUE
MATHURA
Claim: Mosque situated at Lord Krishna's birthplace



ATALA MASJID
JAUNPUR
Claim: Mosque built on remains of temple for goddess Atala Devi

TAJ MAHAL, *AGRA*
Claim: Iconic mausoleum was originally a Shiva temple called 'Tejo Mahalaya'

SHAMSI SHAHI MOSQUE
BADAUN
Claim: 11th century mosque built atop the site of a Nilkanth Mahadev temple

be excavated." The Congress has taken a more combative stance. Party leaders Rahul and Priyanka Gandhi have openly criticised the BJP for "undermining" constitutional law and stoking communal tensions. Congress spokesperson Akhilesh Pratap Singh says, "The BJP's denials are a complete farce. They are trying to divert attention from real issues." However, the Opposition's fragmented approach has allowed the BJP to mostly dominate the narrative. The stakes are high. After its bumper haul of 37 Lok Sabha seats in 2024—the biggest chunk of the INDIA bloc's 43 seats—the SP looms as a formidable contender for the assembly election due in 2027. The legal battles over religious sites, hence, could play a pivotal role. ■

MAHARASHTRA

A MURDER UNSETTLES THE MAHAYUTI

By Dhaval S. Kulkarni

More than a month after its swashbuckling victory in the Maharashtra assembly election, the Mahayuti government faces a crisis over allegations of murder and extortion involving close aides of Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) minister Dhananjay Munde. The fact that former minister and Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) MLA Suresh Dhas is leading the charge against Munde suggests fractures within the ruling coalition. The crescendo of calls for his resignation is only rising.

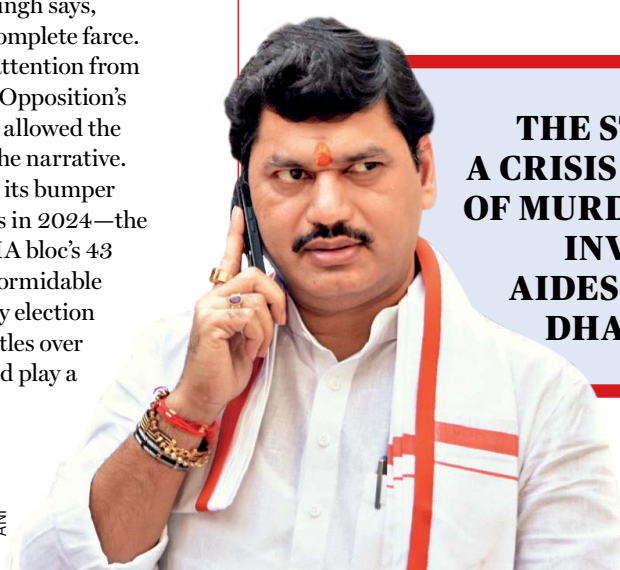
On December 9, Santosh Deshmukh, sarpanch of Massajog village in Beed district's Kaij taluka and a BJP supporter, was abducted and brutally murdered after he reportedly resisted extortion targeting a windmill company, Avaada Energy. Walmik Karad, a close aide of Munde, has been charged in the Rs 2 crore extortion case filed two days after the murder, though he had initially not been named in the murder case.

Although nine people, including Karad, were arrested, his surrender after missing for days at the Criminal Investigation Department (CID) office in Pune on December 31 embarrassed law enforcement. Karad, the former deputy municipal chief of Parli, is widely seen as the constituency manager and enforcer for Munde, who holds the food and civil supplies portfolio. He is alleged to control sand mining, government contract allocations and the sale of ash from the local thermal power plant.

Dhas, who represents the Ashti constituency in Beed district, has launched a fusillade of charges against Munde, Karad and NCP leaders. He claims the murder plot was hatched in May 2024 and accuses Munde of facilitating a deal between Karad and the windmill company at his official residence in Mumbai, where the initial demand for Rs 3 crore was settled at Rs 2 crore.

Anti-corruption activist Anjali Damania, who has taken on Munde, has also found an

THE STATE GOVT FACES A CRISIS OVER ALLEGATIONS OF MURDER AND EXTORTION INVOLVING CLOSE AIDES OF NCP MINISTER DHANANJAY MUNDE



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